teachings. But this papal bull was itself a contested document. It came not from either Rome or from Avignon but from Pisa, where the College of Cardinals had finally gathered and agreed to depose both competing popes in favor of a third, compromise candidate: the Franciscan Alexander V.

The condemnation of Wycliffe was one of Alexander V's first acts. Unfortunately, neither of the other two popes would agree to step down. Now, in an excruciatingly embarrassing development, there were *three* popes in the west.

Wenceslaus, still king of Bohemia, decided to recognize Alexander V as the genuine article. This meant that the bull against Wycliffism went into full and drastic effect in Bohemia, where it was published in March of 1410.

Jan Hus, along with several other Bohemian supporters of Wycliffe's ideas, took their copies of Wycliffe's writings to the Archbishop of Prague with a personal appeal. The books had been obtained "at great trouble and cost" and contained many things of value. It was ridiculous to burn them: "By the same reasoning, we must burn the books of Aristotle, the commentaries of Averrhoes, or the works of Origen." The archbishop ignored them and ordered the bonfire built. At least two hundred books were burned, over the protests of their owners; two days later the archbishop excommunicated Hus and his colleagues as well.[11]

The archbishop's autocratic decision did not sit well with most of Prague, particularly since it was rumored that he had saved the gold bindings and knobs from the most valuable books for himself. Songs were sung in the street: "The Bishop burnt the books," one went, "but ne'er knew he / What was in them written." Groups of rioters burst into churches and chased the priests away from the altars. Hus did not help, preaching a sermon that strongly suggested that the archbishop might be the Antichrist. And Wenceslaus IV did nothing to calm the tensions when he ordered the archbishop to pay back the cost of the burned books; Alexander V had suddenly and unexpectedly died, after only ten months on the third papal throne, which meant that the king of Bohemia could straddle the fence for a little while to see which way the wind was blowing.[12]

As it happened, it had shifted. Alexander V's successor in Pisa, John XXIII, confirmed Hus's excommunication and tactlessly criticized Bohemia for being "full of heresy." Wenceslaus didn't appreciate this wholesale condemnation of his kingdom. He told Hus to leave Prague, but refused to act against him any further; and for a number of months, Hus went on preaching and writing outside of the capital city: rejecting the claim of the pope to be Peter's heir, condemning indulgences, and drawing more and more followers into his circle.[13]